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THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 20, 2025

Trump’s attack deepens breach with Ukraine

Pentagon nominee with ties to Steward faces questions from Warren

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

The chief executive of the private equity group that yielded a roughly \$800 million profit from its investment in Steward Health Care is set to face the Senate soon in his bid to serve as a top official at the Pentagon, and his company’s involvement in the now-troubled hospital chain is drawing scrutiny.

The extent of Cerberus Capital Management chief executive Stephen Feinberg’s involvement with Steward was among the questions Senator Elizabeth Warren posed in a letter sent ahead of his upcoming confirmation hearing. The letter includes dozens of issues the Massachusetts Democrat has about the billionaire’s nomination as deputy defense secretary.

“Cerberus, under your leadership, has exemplified the concerns that I have long had about private equity firms: that its focus on debt-fueled acquisitions, managed for the short-term and for the benefit of insider executives, ultimately leaves the companies it acquires as hollowed-out shells and

CERBERUS, Page A6

‘A Dictator without Elections, Zelenskyy better move fast or he is not going to have a Country left.’

TRUMP ON TRUTH SOCIAL



Trump is ‘caught in a web of disinformation.’

... I would like to have more truth with the Trump team.’

PRESIDENT VOLODYMYR ZELENSKY

FIGHTING BACK IN BOSTON

Hundreds of federal workers rallied to protest layoffs and funding freezes. Here are some of their stories. **B1.**

PARKS FEEL THE PINCH

From Yosemite to the Grand Canyon, federal cuts are threatening to harm the visitor experience. **A2.**

Post filled with falsehoods focuses on Zelensky

By Andrew E. Kramer, Constant Méheut, and Anton Troianovski

NEW YORK TIMES

KYIV — The simmering feud between President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine and President Trump escalated Wednesday when Trump mocked his counterpart in a post filled with falsehoods, calling him a “Dictator without Elections.”

His comments came hours after Zelensky said the US leader had been “caught in a web of disinformation” from Russia over the war in Ukraine.

The pointed exchange was set off by a meeting of American and Russian officials to open talks on ending the war in Ukraine that excluded the Ukrainian government. After that meeting in Saudi Arabia on Tuesday, Trump suggested that Ukraine had started the war, a comment that brought a strong rebuttal from Zelensky on Wednesday morning.

“I would like to have more truth with the Trump team,” Zelensky said in some of the most overt criticism yet of Trump and his view

TRUMP, Page A6



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Jessica Farren and her husband have decided not to have their 2-year-old daughter vaccinated or get any jabs themselves.

AS COVID MEMORIES FADE, SHOT RESISTANCE HARDENS

Mass., long a leader in vaccination rates, is now falling behind US average

By Robert Weisman and Neena Hagen

GLOBE STAFF

Jessica Farren, 38, a stay-at-home mom from North Attleborough, received COVID shots during the pandemic but regrets rolling up her sleeve. She doesn’t understand why she still caught COVID after being vaccinated. Farren and her husband, Nick, have now forsworn all vaccines for themselves and their 2-year-old daughter.

“I’m no longer going to let them stick me with a needle,” she said.

Five years after the COVID outbreak

sparked a frantic push for vaccines to build what public health officials called “herd immunity,” a growing number of Americans don’t want to be part of the herd.

The rapid COVID vaccines rollout was credited with saving millions of lives. While scientists and health officials hailed it as a triumph of science and logistics, a potent mix of politics, fatigue, and misinformation has taken hold in recent years, leaving much of the public wary.

Health care providers, who strongly recommend vaccines as safe and effective, said such hesitation and outright resistance to vaccines have become disturbingly common even in Massachusetts, a state at the forefront

of the campaign to develop and distribute COVID vaccines.

Indeed, a Globe data analysis shows vaccination rates in the state, which have long surpassed the US average, have now dropped below those of the nation for COVID — and even more dramatically for flu, where vaccine uptake has fallen by half among those 19 and younger.

Most alarming to doctors and health officials in Massachusetts is a decline in immunization for serious childhood diseases, such as measles and mumps, that were largely suppressed through vaccines.

The motives for those refusing vaccines

VACCINES, Page A7

Numbers don’t lie: state’s in a spending boom

Budget has expanded greatly over last 7 years, with help from pandemic

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Under Governor Maura Healey’s \$62 billion state budget proposal, there would be more taxpayer money for the MBTA and local schools, major cuts to some health and social service programs, and higher prices on candy bars.

Beyond the individual line items, however, Healey’s plan represents a notable milestone for the state: If adopted, Massachusetts would spend nearly 50 percent more than it did just seven years ago.

The state’s spending has boomed since the onset of the COVID pandemic, a Globe review of budget data found, far outpacing previous eras due to what state officials, budget watchers, and others described as a stew of factors, some of them unprecedented.

Health care costs have shot up, often outpacing inflation. The state, while slicing taxes for

BUDGET, Page A10

Scammers target seniors looking for love online

By Scooty Nickerson
GLOBE STAFF

The retired public school teacher’s life was thrown into chaos after she went looking for love on the internet back in 2021.

Nancy was in her 70s, lonely and beset by a handful of health issues, when she found what she was looking for while perusing WhatsApp and Facebook.

A charming man called Will Joshua, who claimed to be a military general in Afghanistan, chatted with her via WhatsApp and filled her with confidence — then convinced her to send him thousands of dollars, police reports show.

Then there was Dr. Wesley Robeson, a “diplomatic surgeon” who, according to police and neighbors, professed his love to Nancy — at least online. He promised to set her up in a New York penthouse if she helped fund his

ROMANCE, Page A10

Breakfast restaurants are struggling to keep the price of egg dishes reasonable during the bird flu outbreak. **D1.**

Icy streets and sidewalks are making things tough for ev-

eryone and sending people to ERs with broken bones. **B1.**

Israelis waited anxiously for the release of the bodies of four hostages by Hamas as part of the cease-fire. **A4.**

Wintry remix

Thursday: Flurries, cold. High 28-33.

Friday: And now it’s windy again. High 32-37.

High tide: 4:11 a.m., 4:49 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:33 Sunset: 5:23

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C9.



MINAS PANAGIOTAKIS/GETTY IMAGES

TITLE FIGHT

Brad Marchand and Canada will square off against the United States tonight in the 4 Nations Face-Off final at TD Garden. The intensity of the tournament has grabbed fans, making it a hot ticket. **C1.**

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